V

Vacaspati Mishra (841 or 976 CE): a polymath whose works include the *Nyayavarttikatatparyatika* expounding *Uddyotakara*'s (600–50 CE) commentary on the aphorisms (*sutras*) basic to the ***Nyaya*** school; the *Tattvavaisharadi* on the *Yoga-Sutras*; the *Tattvakaumudi* on the *Samkhya-karikas*; the *Nyayakanika* on ***Mandana Mishra***'s *Vidhiviveka*; the *Tattvabindu* (***Purva Mimamsa***) and the *Bhamati* commentary on ***Shankara***'s commentary on the ***Brahma-Sutras***. In the last, his definition of reality as undeniable self-evidence means that only the conscious inner self, the constant witness of all experiences, can be considered real. He claims that there are two forms of ignorance (***avidya***): a subjective psychological affliction (*klesha*), and the objective indescribable underlying cause of limited personality and what are experienced as the material objects. The limited self is the substrate (*ashraya*) of ***avidya*** and the absolute foundational reality (***Brahman***), understood as purely reflexive consciousness, its object. The content of the illusory experience of duality is due to cosmic ***avidya***. The content of illusory experiences can neither be described as real nor as unreal; they persist for a time but are eventually negated by other experiences.

Further reading: Potter 1977; Ram-Prasad 2002

Vaibhashika: Buddhist school belonging to the ***Sarvastivada*** ('everything exists' family) holding that underlying all material and mental processes there are many types of real atomic factors (***dharma***). Each atomic factor and two modes of existence are actualised and non-actualised. Each occurs and disappears here in a single moment. Each has an essential nature (***svabhava***) that remains the same in past, present and future.